

Boston Sunday Globe

Serving our community since 1872

DECEMBER 29, 2024

Sandra Birchmore put her trust in the police. They broke it.



She was 23 years old and pregnant when she was found dead in her Canton apartment in 2021. In a matter of months, state investigators determined it was a case of suicide. But time and again, the Globe reveals, those investigators gave the benefit of the doubt to the Stoughton police officer now accused of killing her to protect his secrets.

IN THE GLOBE MAGAZINE



Can traffic cameras curb the notorious Mass. driver?

Lawmakers look to allow automated enforcement

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

The intersection of Congress and Sudbury streets is one of the many crossings where all the trappings that make driving in Boston so notorious converge: long queues of cars, their impatient drivers honking horns and cheating into the bus lanes as mopeds weave through the stalled traffic and pedestrians dodge the vehicles ignoring the no-turn-on-red sign.

In the span of 30 minutes on a recent December afternoon, within sight of City Hall, more than 20 motorists raced through a red light with no sign of enforcement, despite a Boston police station just a few yards away on Sudbury Street.

From her perch at the neighboring Boston Public Market, Naomi Cannistraci, 57, owner of The Popover Lady, witnesses the traffic mayhem every day and said the proximity to the police station “makes no difference. People don’t care.”

Such driving seems to have become accepted. **CAMERAS, Page A9**



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

A car ignored traffic rules at Congress and Sudbury streets. Vehicles in bus lanes are one of many violations on Boston roads.

‘This is my way out.’

PRESTON THORPE, on the outside job he works while incarcerated in Maine



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Victoria Scott worked remotely from inside the Southern Maine Women’s Re-Entry Center in Windham, Maine.

In Maine, remote work gives prisoners a lifeline

40-plus have landed internships, jobs in past two years

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

Every weekday morning at 8:30, Preston Thorpe makes himself a cup of instant coffee and opens his laptop to find the coding tasks awaiting his seven-person team at Unlocked Labs. Like many remote workers, Thorpe, the nonprofit’s principal engineer, works out in the middle of the day and often stays at his computer late into the night.

But outside Thorpe’s window, there’s a soaring chain-link fence topped with coiled barbed wire. And at noon and 4 p.m. every day, a prison guard peers into his room to make sure he’s

where he’s supposed to be at the Mountain View Correctional Facility in Charleston, Maine, where he’s serving his 12th year for two drug-related convictions in New Hampshire, including intent to distribute synthetic opioids.

Remote work has spread far and wide since the pandemic spurred a work-from-home revolution of sorts, but perhaps no place more unexpectedly than behind prison walls. Thorpe is one of more than 40 people incarcerated in Maine’s state prison system who have landed internships and jobs with outside companies

PRISON WORK, Page A11

State paid high price for food at shelters

But E. Boston caterer got poor reviews, including complaints of raw chicken

By Deirdre Fernandes
and Stephanie Ebbert
GLOBE STAFF

The East Boston caterer handpicked by government officials to deliver meals to family homeless shelters began racking up poor reviews even before its contract was finalized.

The meals in a Bedford shelter were giving people stomachaches, a Bedford legislator warned Governor Maura Healey’s administration, and the food was ending up in the trash. A top official in the state’s immigration office told his boss after visiting a shelter that the food vendor — Spinelli’s Ravioli Manufacturing — “is truly awful.”

Just four weeks into the job, Spinelli’s delivered undercooked chicken, emails reveal.

Despite problems that were evident from the get-go, and that would be raised repeatedly in the months to come, state officials accepted the steep prices of Spinelli’s early invoices, and, with no evident negotiation, handed the caterer a no-bid contract worth \$10 million in late September 2023, according to emails and text messages reviewed by the Globe.

The caterer ultimately collected \$9.4 million — costing taxpayers \$19.38 a meal, state records show. That rate was 30 percent higher than what the Massachusetts Office for Refugees and Immigrants paid small vendors and local restaurants — \$14.85 a meal — to deliver to shelters that weren’t on Spinelli’s list. The

SHELTERS, Page A10

VOL. 306, NO. 182

Suggested retail price
\$6.00



The Patriots lost to the Chargers, 40-7, leaving New England with a 3-13 record with one game left this season. **C1.**

After months in a crowded shelter, a Haitian family defied the odds and found a home of

their own in Boston. **B1.**

According to our critics, the year’s top TV shows had some things in common: good characters, sharp dialogue, and emotional stakes that feel meaningful. **SundayArts N1.**

Americans pride ourselves on protecting even the speech we hate, but law professor Mary Anne Franks argues that an uncritical interpretation of the First Amendment ends up undermining free expression. **Ideas, K1.**

Drops in the bucket

Sunday: Rainy, cloudy.
High: 47-52. Low: 43-48.
Monday: Similar.
Complete report, **C22.**
Deaths, **C16-21.**



STILL TIME LEFT TO DONATE

HELP GLOBE SANTA BRING BOOKS & TOYS TO KIDS IN NEED.



SCAN TO
DONATE
VIA VENMO



SCAN TO
DONATE AT
GLOBESANTA.ORG



Boston Globe
FOUNDATION

